

PROPERTY AND equality



▲ Ornate object

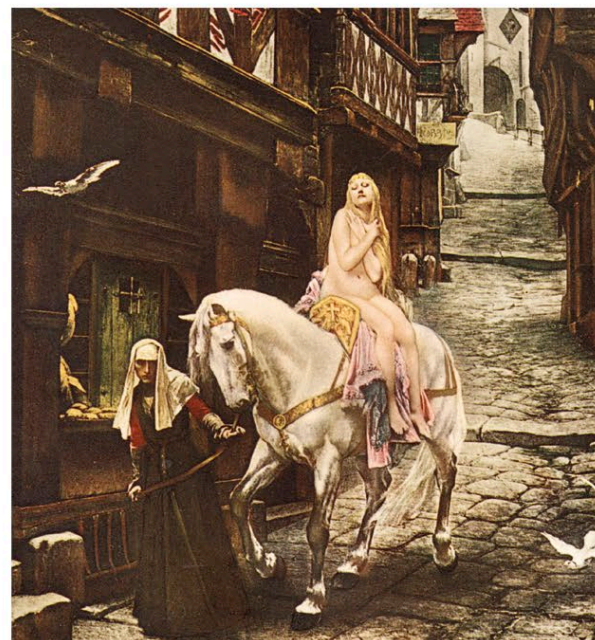
Women's brooches, worn on each shoulder to hold back a cloak or shawl, were more embellished than those of men. This example was found in the grave of a woman from the kingdom of Kent, southeast England.

ANGLO-SAXON SETTLEMENT

Anglo-Saxon women in England enjoyed a surprising degree of equality. A seminal study published in 1984 described females of this period as “near equal companions to males in their lives ... much more than in any other era before modern time.” The Angles and Saxons were Germanic tribes who had migrated from northwestern Europe and displaced the Romans in Britain. By about 600 CE, a “heptarchy” of seven Anglo-Saxon kingdoms arose that lasted until Wessex emerged as the leading kingdom in the early 9th century. Anglo-Saxon rule continued until the Norman invasion in 1066.

Property rights

Not a great deal of information survives about the lives of Anglo-Saxon queens, although a few, like Margaret of Wessex and Ealhswith (wife of Alfred the Great) were pious enough to be venerated as saints. Legal documents and archaeological evidence, however, do give valuable insights into women's status. Women had property rights, and many landowners were female. A number of English place-names reflect this; Wolverhampton, for example, was named for its founder Wulfrun,

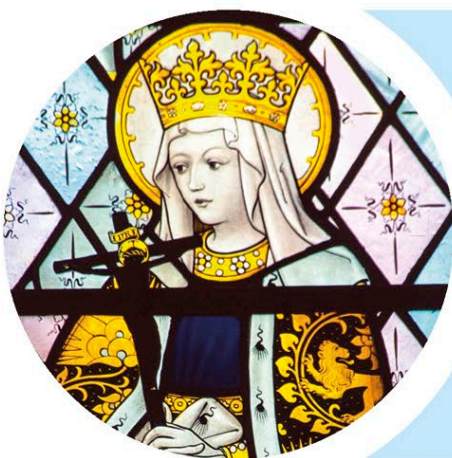


▲ Streaking in protest

Lady Godiva was an 11th-century noblewoman who, according to legend, rode naked through the streets of Coventry to protest against the oppressive taxation imposed by her husband, the earl of Mercia, on his tenants.

a 10th-century noblewoman. Women brought matters to court to settle disputes, and could make binding oaths. One-quarter of surviving

Anglo-Saxon wills were made by women. Married women retained a separate legal identity and property rights independent of their husband. After the wedding the husband paid his wife a *morgengifu* (morning-gift) in money, livestock, land, or jewelry which she retained full control over. A widow could not be forced to remarry, but if she did she would sometimes have to give up part of her late



"SHE WAS CALLED
MARGARET ...
PRECIOUS IN FAITH
AND WORKS."

BISHOP TURBOT, *LIFE OF ST. MARGARET*, 12TH CENTURY CE